Whose Contribution Counts? Generative AI, Cultural Participation and Collective Authorship in Research-Creation

Proposed Plan of Study — PhD in Communication & Culture, Fall 2027

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I am an artistic practitioner and researcher working through research-creation, currently completing an MA in Interactive Arts and Technology at Simon Fraser University after training in architecture and landscape architecture. I build interactive 3D environments and multiplayer systems that examine how technical mediation shapes relations among participants. My doctoral project asks how generative AI (GenAI) systems, including models, interfaces and the platforms through which they are accessed, reorganize interpretive authority and collective authorship in collaborative artistic practice. When a model turns a participant's words, images or sounds into shared material, whose interpretation becomes visible, whose contribution remains recognizable, who can revise or refuse the transformation, and who is credited or held responsible? These questions reach further: platform companies shape much of this mediation, models may privilege, flatten or misrecognize culturally situated expression, and a system's record of who supplied what seldom settles credit or responsibility.

My objects of study are collaborative art-making with a limited set of GenAI and non-AI tools, and the collaborative artworks and installation produced through that process. Using the program's research-creation option, the project begins with my own studio inquiry, followed by consultation with paid practitioners; workshops with about 18–24 adult interdisciplinary artists and community-engaged practitioners in three cohorts, with participant observation; semi-structured focus groups; and the co-creation of a room-scale installation, proposed for exhibition at York, in which revisions, refusals and contested credit remain visible. Analysis combines episode, thematic and version analysis. Participants may refuse GenAI at any point without losing standing in the collaboration and retain negotiated authority over use, revision, attribution and withdrawal.

The project would contribute a communication-and-culture account of how GenAI redistributes interpretive authority, a research-creation method for studying it, and an artwork that keeps those negotiations open to public encounter. It is primarily situated in Technology in Practice and secondarily in Media & Culture, and fits the program's aim of "the application of critical theory and research." I hope to work with Dr. Rebecca Caines, whose research on improvisation as methodology, socially responsive creative technologies and GenAI as a critical improvisation practice grounds this approach.

In architecture at Tabriz Islamic Art University (Best Dissertation Award, 2016) and landscape architecture at Istanbul Technical University, where I studied perception of mediated environments (eCAADe 2023), I designed space as a medium of social life. In the iViz Lab, my thesis asked what happens when a technical system translates an ambiguous human state into a shared representation. I built a networked Unity game that rendered teammates' heart rate and heart-rate variability as one integrated ambient cue (accepted at ACM ISS 2026), and BioTerrarium, a world whose fog and light respond to the player, evaluated in a completed within-subjects study with 24 participants (manuscript under revision). Participants asked for visibility to be optional and mutable, with an immediate off switch. The PhD extends that question from bodily signals to cultural production.